—Jean-Georges Perrin,
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preface

Each one of us authors has experienced—at length and at different companies—the old way of "doing data," usually through centralized data lakes and data warehouses in combination with a set of central teams organized inside an analytics function. The old way basically looked like this:

1. Multiple decentralized development teams have data that is accessible through storage systems like a shared drive, a decentralized database, a Representational State Transfer (REST) API, or any other interface.
2. One or more centralized data teams are tasked with collecting this data into one monolithic pot. This is either a data lake or a data warehouse.
3. The same set of teams is tasked with transforming this data into something useful.
4. Multiple decentralized analysts, development teams, or machine learning (ML) teams pick up that transformed data and convert it into value in the form of reports, recommendation systems, or anything else they can think of.

We learned the hard way that this concept has its limits, producing a bottleneck in terms of both technology and team capacities. We all saw companies struggling to get the flow from data to value to be as productive as the companies needed it to be. Then the data mesh and the ideas behind it appeared on the horizon.

The *data mesh* is a decentralization paradigm. It decentralizes the ownership of data, its transformation into information, and its serving. It aims to increase the value extraction from data by removing bottlenecks in the data value stream by these means.